Chapter 25

Introduction

Ulrike Mosel



Figure 1: Teop Island and the reef

The lagoon of the Teop region includes Teop Island and is very rich in fish and other marine animals.[1] Consequently, there has not been the need to develop special fishing techniques for the deep ocean. Shoffner (1976: 185) remarks in his

[1]For example, search the Semantic Domain of the MTED for "animals, fishes" and the Part of Speech field for "N2" and find 131 entries. Or search the Semantic Domain for "animals, shellfish" and the Part of Speech field for "N3" and find 53 entries. These data were collected by the Teop team without any questionnaires.

Ulrike Mosel. 2026. Introduction. In Ulrike Mosel (ed.), *The material culture of the Teop people of Bougainville*, 185–186. Berlin: Language Science Press. DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.22880276

detailed chapter on Marine Resource Activities, "The Teop are not great maritime travellers, seldom venturing more than a quarter of a mile into deep water."

Decades ago traditional hand-made fishing nets and lines have been replaced with *kave sitiring* 'nets made of plastic strings' and *kara sitiring* 'plastic strings', but intensive team work with elderly fishing experts enabled the authors Enoch Magum, Naphtali Maion, Mark Tahi, and the graphic artist Neville Vitahi to write and illustrate the following chapters on catching turtles with the huge *kave goroto* 'turtle net', see Chapters 26, 27, and 28, the construction of the bamboo-frame net called *kakavei*, see Chapter 29, two net-fishing techniques called *varigomo* and *seige*, see Chapters 30 and 31, and angling with a kite to which the fishing line with a bait is attached, see Chapter 34.[2]

Examples of fishing methods that were still practiced during our fieldwork are *tanaa* 'group fishing', see Chapter 32, and *vavaiku* 'a kind of angling', see Chapter 33, and those kinds of catching fish and gathering seafood that are only done by women on the reef during low tide. These are catching wrasses by hand, see Chapter 35, fish poisoning, see Chapters 36, 37, and 38, and digging sea-sausages, see Chapter 39.

Further fishing methods like *rooroto*^{2} 'fish for tuna', *taragao* 'angling mackerels' and *vavaakopo*^{2} 'fishing with cole lamps', are described in the MTED.[3]

The data for the texts and descriptions for the MTED were collected by the Teop team without any questionnaires.

[2]Compare Blackwood's descriptions of the "net on frame" and the "fishing kite" (1935: 342-346, 348-350). Shoffner reports that already during his fieldwork 1973-1974 turtle nets and fishing kites were no longer in use in the Teop area (1976: 208, 201).

[3]If you search the Semantic Domain for "fishing", you find 110 entries that are related to fishing methods. Fishing tools are listed in the Semantic Domain "tools and weapons" with references to 125 entries.